SPOKEN ENGLISH

Complete Unit-wise Notes (Units I to V)

Spoken English is the ability to use English correctly and confidently in everyday situations. It combines **grammar** (correct structure), **vocabulary** (the right words), **pronunciation** (clear sounds, stress and intonation), **conversation** (speaking with others) and **listening and body language** (receiving and supporting the message).

Course Outcomes (CLOs)

- Speak English with proficiency.
- Demonstrate knowledge in the correct use of grammar and pronunciation.
- Develop an appreciation of practical ways of learning to speak simple and correct English.
- Use the studies undertaken in the field of spoken English in a range of practical contexts.
- Apply knowledge and skills in the field of spoken English to relevant contexts, thus aiding in handling everyday situations.

Units at a Glance

Unit	Title	Main Topics
I	Working with Grammar	Sentences, parts of speech, auxiliary verbs, voice, comparison, determiners, agreement, punctuation, common errors
II	Vocabulary Building and Pronunciation	Word formation, synonyms, antonyms, homonyms, one-word substitutes, idioms, joining sentences, sounds, stress, intonation
III	Conversational Skills	Introductions, describing, extempore, persuasive and descriptive speeches, narration
IV	Group Communication	Group discussion, leaders, tasks, cohesion, group presentations, PowerPoint
V	Listening Skills and Non-verbal Communication	Listening, barriers, body language, gestures, posture, eye contact, etiquette

UNIT I - WORKING WITH GRAMMAR

1. Sentence Construction

A sentence is a group of words that expresses a complete thought. It must have a **subject** (who or what) and a **predicate** (what is said about the subject). Basic pattern: **Subject + Verb + Object/Complement**.

- **Subject + Verb:** The baby smiled.
- **Subject + Verb + Object:** She wrote a letter.
- **Subject + Verb + Complement:** He is a teacher.
- **Subject + Verb + Indirect Object + Direct Object:** He gave me a pen.

2. Types of Sentences

By function:

Type	Purpose	Example
Declarative	States a fact or opinion	The train arrived on time.
Interrogative	Asks a question	Where do you live?
Imperative	Gives a command or request	Please close the door.
Exclamatory	Shows strong feeling	What a beautiful day!

By structure:

Type	Meaning	Example
Simple	One independent clause	I like tea.
Compound	Two independent clauses joined by and, but, or, so	I like tea, but she likes coffee.
Complex	One independent + one or more dependent clauses	I stayed home because it was raining.
Compound-complex	Two independent + at least one dependent clause	I stayed home because it rained, and she went out.

3. Parts of Speech

Part	Function	Examples
Noun	Name of a person, place, thing or idea	Ravi, Chennai, book, honesty
Pronoun	Takes the place of a noun	he, she, they, it, who
Verb	Shows action or state	run, is, think
Adjective	Describes a noun	tall boy, red car
Adverb	Describes a verb, adjective or adverb	walks slowly, very good
Preposition	Shows relation to a noun or pronoun	in, on, at, under, between
Conjunction	Joins words, phrases or clauses	and, but, because, although
Interjection	Expresses sudden feeling	Oh! Wow! Alas!

4. Auxiliary Verbs

Auxiliary (helping) verbs work with the main verb to show tense, voice, mood or question form.

- **Primary auxiliaries:** be (am, is, are, was, were), have (has, had), do (does, did). Example: She **is** singing. They **have** finished. **Do** you know him?
- **Modal auxiliaries:** can, could, may, might, shall, should, will, would, must, ought to. They show ability, permission, possibility, advice or obligation. Example: You **should** rest. **May** I come in?

5. Singular and Plural

- Add **-s**: book, books. Add **-es** after s, x, z, ch, sh: bus, buses; box, boxes.
- Consonant + y becomes **-ies**: city, cities. Vowel + y adds -s: boy, boys.
- Many words ending in f/fe change to **-ves**: leaf, leaves; knife, knives.
- **Irregular:** man, men; woman, women; child, children; foot, feet; tooth, teeth; mouse, mice; person, people.
- **Same in both:** sheep, deer, fish. **Always plural:** scissors, trousers, clothes. **Uncountable (no plural):** information, advice, furniture, luggage.

6. Active and Passive Voice

In the active voice the subject performs the action. In the passive voice the subject receives the action. Passive = **object becomes subject + be-verb + past participle (V3) + by + agent**.

Tense	Active	Passive
Simple present	She writes a letter.	A letter is written by her.
Simple past	He broke the glass.	The glass was broken by him.
Simple future	They will finish the work.	The work will be finished by them.
Present continuous	I am reading a book.	A book is being read by me.
Present perfect	We have won the match.	The match has been won by us.

7. Degrees of Comparison

Positive	Comparative	Superlative
tall	taller	tallest
happy	happier	happiest
beautiful	more beautiful	most beautiful
good / well	better	best
bad	worse	worst
far	farther / further	farthest / furthest

Use **than** with the comparative (She is taller than me) and **the** with the superlative (He is the best player). Do not use double comparatives such as 'more better'.

8. Determiners

Determiners come before a noun to show which one, how many or whose.

- **Articles:** a, an, the. Use *an* before a vowel sound (an hour, an umbrella) and *a* before a consonant sound (a university).
- **Demonstratives:** this, that, these, those.
- **Possessives:** my, your, his, her, its, our, their.

- **Quantifiers:** some, any, much, many, few, little, several, enough.
- **Numerals:** one, two, first, second. **Distributives:** each, every, either, neither.

9. Subject-Verb Agreement

- A singular subject takes a singular verb; a plural subject takes a plural verb. The **boy plays**; the **boys play**.
- Subjects joined by **and** take a plural verb: Ravi and Kumar **are** friends.
- With **either...or / neither...nor**, the verb agrees with the nearer subject: Neither the teacher nor the students **were** present.
- Words such as each, every, everyone, nobody, someone take a singular verb: Everyone **is** here.
- Collective nouns (team, committee, family) take a singular verb when seen as one unit: The team **has** won.
- Ignore words between the subject and verb: The **box** of apples **is** heavy.

10. Punctuation

Mark	Use	Example
Full stop (.)	Ends a statement	I am a student.
Comma (,)	Separates items in a list, clauses, or direct address	I bought apples, mangoes, and grapes.
Question mark (?)	Ends a direct question	What is your name?
Exclamation mark (!)	Shows strong feeling	Stop that!
Apostrophe (')	Possession and contractions	Ravi's book; don't
Colon (:)	Introduces a list or explanation	You need three things: a pen, paper, and time.
Semicolon (;)	Joins closely related clauses	He was tired; he went to bed.
Quotation marks	Enclose direct speech	She said, "I am ready."
Hyphen (-)	Joins words	well-known author

11. Common Errors and Usage

Wrong	Correct	Reason
He don't know the answer.	He doesn't know the answer.	Singular subject needs does
I am knowing him.	I know him.	Stative verbs are not used in continuous form
She is more taller than me.	She is taller than me.	No double comparative
Each of the boys have a pen.	Each of the boys has a pen.	Each is singular
I have seen him yesterday.	I saw him yesterday.	Past time word needs simple past
He gave me many advices.	He gave me much advice.	Advice is uncountable
The furnitures are new.	The furniture is new.	Furniture is uncountable
Less students came.	Fewer students came.	Fewer for countable nouns

Wrong	Correct	Reason
I look forward to meet you.	I look forward to meeting you.	'to' here is a preposition, so use -ing
Me and him went.	He and I went.	Use subject pronouns as subjects

UNIT II - VOCABULARY BUILDING AND PRONUNCIATION

1. Word Formation

- **Prefix** (added at the start): un-happy, dis-agree, re-write, mis-understand, pre-view.
- **Suffix** (added at the end): happi-ness, care-ful, teach-er, act-ion, quick-ly.
- **Compounding** (two words joined): sun + flower = sunflower; black + board = blackboard.
- **Blending:** breakfast + lunch = brunch; smoke + fog = smog.
- **Clipping:** examination = exam; laboratory = lab.
- **Acronyms:** NASA, UNESCO, laser.

2. Synonyms and Antonyms

Word	Synonym	Antonym
Brave	Courageous	Cowardly
Rapid	Quick	Slow
Ancient	Old	Modern
Generous	Liberal	Stingy
Permit	Allow	Forbid
Victory	Triumph	Defeat
Create	Make	Destroy
Honest	Truthful	Dishonest

3. Homonyms

Words that sound or look the same but differ in meaning. **Homophones** sound the same but are spelt differently; **homographs** are spelt the same but have different meanings.

Homophones	Meaning
there / their / they're	in that place / belonging to them / they are
to / too / two	towards / also / the number 2
write / right	to put words on paper / correct
piece / peace	a part / calm
principal / principle	head of a school / a rule or belief
bear (animal) / bear (carry)	homograph with different meanings

4. One-Word Substitutes

Phrase	One word
A person who writes his own life story	Autobiographer (the book: autobiography)
A child whose parents are dead	Orphan
One who does not believe in God	Atheist
A lover of books	Bibliophile
One who hates mankind	Misanthrope

Phrase	One word
One who eats both plants and meat	Omnivorous
A person who walks on foot	Pedestrian
A place where birds are kept	Aviary
Government by the people	Democracy
That which cannot be read	Illegible
A person who speaks many languages	Polyglot

5. Changing One Part of Speech to Another

Noun	Verb	Adjective	Adverb
beauty	beautify	beautiful	beautifully
success	succeed	successful	successfully
decision	decide	decisive	decisively
strength	strengthen	strong	strongly
choice	choose	choosy	-
pleasure	please	pleasant	pleasantly

6. Odd-One-Out

Find the word that does not belong to the group.

Examples

1. Apple, mango, carrot, banana - **carrot** (a vegetable; the rest are fruits).
2. Happy, joyful, cheerful, sad - **sad** (the rest are synonyms).
3. Run, jump, walk, table - **table** (a noun; the rest are verbs).
4. Chennai, Madurai, Delhi, Coimbatore - **Delhi** (not in Tamil Nadu).

7. Idioms and Phrases

Idiom	Meaning	Example
A piece of cake	Very easy	The test was a piece of cake.
Break the ice	Start a conversation	He told a joke to break the ice.
Once in a blue moon	Very rarely	We meet once in a blue moon.
Spill the beans	Reveal a secret	Don't spill the beans about the party.
Hit the nail on the head	Say exactly the right thing	You hit the nail on the head.
Burn the midnight oil	Work late at night	She burnt the midnight oil before exams.
Under the weather	Slightly unwell	I am feeling under the weather.
Cost an arm and a leg	Very expensive	That phone cost an arm and a leg.

8. Joining Sentences

- **Coordinating conjunctions** (and, but, or, so): It was late. We left. = It was late, so we left.
- **Subordinating conjunctions** (because, although, if, when, since): He was tired. He kept working. = **Although** he was tired, he kept working.
- **Relative pronouns** (who, which, that): I met a man. He teaches music. = I met a man **who** teaches music.
- **Participles:** She opened the door. She walked in. = **Opening** the door, she walked in.
- **too...to / so...that:** He is too weak to walk. = He is so weak that he cannot walk.

9. Vowel and Consonant Sounds

English has 5 vowel *letters* (a, e, i, o, u) and 21 consonant letters, but about **44 sounds** in standard British pronunciation: **20 vowel sounds** (12 pure vowels or monophthongs and 8 diphthongs) and **24 consonant sounds**.

- **Pure vowels** keep one steady sound: as in *sit*, *see*, *set*, *cat*, *cut*, *put*, *food*, *saw*, *hot*, *hurt*, *car*, *about*.
- **Diphthongs** glide from one vowel sound to another: as in *day*, *go*, *high*, *boy*, *now*, *here*, *hair*, *tour*.
- **Consonants** are grouped by voicing (voiced like b, d, g, v, z; voiceless like p, t, k, f, s), by place (lips, teeth, tongue ridge, throat) and by manner (stops, fricatives, nasals).
- Spelling does not match sound: *though*, *through*, *tough*, *cough* all end in 'ough' but sound different. Always check a dictionary.

10. Word Stress

In words of more than one syllable, one syllable is spoken louder, longer and higher. Wrong stress can make a word hard to understand.

- Two-syllable **nouns and adjectives** usually stress the first syllable: **TA**ble, **PRE**sent (noun), **CLE**ver.
- Two-syllable **verbs** usually stress the second syllable: pre**SENT** (verb), de**CIDE**, re**PORT**.
- Words ending in **-tion, -sion, -ic, -ical, -ity** stress the syllable just before the ending: edu**CA**tion, e**CO**nomic, ca**PA**city.
- The same spelling can change stress with meaning: **REC**ord (noun) and re**CORD** (verb); **OB**ject and ob**JECT**.

11. Sentence Stress

In a sentence, **content words** (nouns, main verbs, adjectives, adverbs, negatives) are stressed. **Function words** (articles, prepositions, auxiliaries, pronouns) are usually weak.

Example

I want to BUY a NEW BOOK from the SHOP.

Changing the stress changes the meaning: **I** did not take your pen (someone else did) / I did not **take** your pen (I borrowed it) / I did not take **your** pen (I took another).

12. Intonation

Intonation is the rise and fall of the voice while speaking. It shows meaning, attitude and emotion.

Pattern	Used for	Example
Falling	Statements, commands, wh-questions	Where do you LIVE? (falls)
Rising	Yes/no questions, requests, doubt	Are you COMING? (rises)
Fall-rise	Uncertainty, polite correction	Well... I SUPPose so.

Pattern	Used for	Example
Rising, rising, falling	Lists	I bought apples, oranges, and BANANAS.

13. Practice in Pronunciation

- Listen to native or standard speakers (news, podcasts) and repeat aloud.
- Use a dictionary with audio to check each new word.
- Record your own voice and compare it with a model.
- Practise tongue twisters: 'She sells sea shells on the sea shore.'
- Practise minimal pairs: ship / sheep, bit / beat, pull / pool, think / sink.

UNIT III - CONVERSATIONAL SKILLS

1. Basics of Conversation

- **Greetings:** Good morning. Hello. How are you? Nice to see you.
- **Introducing yourself:** Hello, I am Ravi. I am from Puducherry. I am studying BCA.
- **Introducing others:** Meena, this is my friend Kumar. Kumar, this is Meena.
- **Asking questions:** Use wh-words (what, where, when, who, why, how) for information and yes/no questions for confirmation. Use polite forms: Could you tell me...? Would you mind...?
- **Responding:** Give a full, polite answer and ask a question back to keep the conversation going.
- **Closing:** It was nice talking to you. See you soon. Take care.

Sample Dialogue
A: Good morning! I don't think we have met. I am Priya.
B: Good morning, Priya. I am Arun. Are you new here?
A: Yes, I joined the college last week. Which department are you in?
B: I am in Computer Applications. Nice to meet you.
A: Nice to meet you too. See you around!

2. Describing People, Places, Situations and Events

- **People:** appearance (height, build, hair), dress, character, habits. 'My teacher is tall and calm. She always smiles and explains patiently.'
- **Places:** location, size, what you see, how it feels. 'Auroville is peaceful, green and quiet.'
- **Situations:** what is happening, who is involved, how people feel.
- **Events:** what, when, where, who, and the order of happenings (first, then, after that, finally).

Tip: Use the five senses and specific adjectives instead of general words such as 'nice' or 'good'.

3. Extempore Speeches

An extempore speech is given on the spot with little or no preparation. Structure it in three parts:

- **Opening:** A quote, question or short statement to catch attention.
- **Body:** Two or three main points, each with a short example.
- **Closing:** A summary and a strong final line.
- Use the minute of thinking time to pick the topic angle and the three points. Speak slowly, pause, and avoid fillers such as 'umm' and 'you know'.

4. Persuasive and Descriptive Speeches

	Persuasive speech	Descriptive speech
Aim	Convince the audience to agree or act	Help the audience picture a person, place or thing
Language	Strong, emotional, uses facts and reasons	Sensory, detailed, vivid adjectives
Structure	Attention - problem - solution - call to action	Overview - details in order (near to far, top to bottom) - impression
Example topic	Why we should avoid plastic	My village in the monsoon

5. Speaking Through Narration

Narration means telling a story or an event in sequence. A good narration has:

- **Setting:** time and place. **Characters:** who is in the story.
- **Plot:** beginning (introduction), middle (problem, rising action, climax) and end (resolution).
- **Past tense** and time connectors: one day, suddenly, meanwhile, at last.
- **Voice:** change pace, pitch and volume to show suspense, surprise or humour.

6. Narrating Stories and Describing Characters

- Begin with a hook: 'Last summer, something strange happened to me.'
- Describe a character through **appearance, speech, actions and feelings**. Show traits by what the character does, not only by labels.
- Describe the situation of the story: the conflict, what the character wants and what stops them.
- End with the outcome and, if suitable, the lesson learnt.

UNIT IV - GROUP COMMUNICATION

1. Basics of Group Discussion (GD)

A group discussion is a structured conversation in which a group exchanges views on a topic to reach a conclusion. It tests knowledge, communication, teamwork, leadership and listening.

- **Stages:** (1) Initiation - start with a definition or a striking fact. (2) Body - present points, respond to others. (3) Summary - close with the group view.
- **Do:** speak clearly, support points with facts, listen, respect others, invite quiet members, stay on topic.
- **Do not:** interrupt, shout, dominate, make personal remarks, or go off topic.
- **Useful phrases:** 'I agree with the point that...', 'I see it differently because...', 'To add to what he said...', 'Let us come back to the topic.'

2. Assigning Tasks to Class Groups

- Divide the class into small groups of 4 to 6 members.
- Give each group a clear task, a time limit and an expected output (a report, a chart, a presentation).
- Assign roles inside each group: leader, speaker, note-taker, timekeeper.

3. Appointing Group Leaders to Communicate

- The leader guides the discussion, divides work, keeps time and speaks for the group.
- Qualities: good listener, clear speaker, fair, calm, and able to motivate.
- A good leader shares the floor so that every member speaks.

4. Completion of Tasks Based on Communication

Tasks succeed when members share information clearly, agree on a plan, check progress and give feedback. Key steps: understand the task, plan, divide work, communicate updates, combine results, review.

5. Group Cohesion Through Communication

Cohesion means the group feels united and works well together. Open and honest communication builds trust; respectful disagreement, shared goals, and appreciation of each member's contribution strengthen cohesion. Poor communication creates misunderstanding, conflict and wasted effort.

6. Group Presentations

- Plan together: decide the topic, main message, and who speaks on which part.
- Structure: introduction - main points - conclusion - questions.
- Practise as a team and keep to the time limit.
- Smooth hand-overs: 'Now my colleague will explain...'. Face the audience, not the screen.
- Every member should speak; support each other during questions.

7. Use of PowerPoint Presentations

- One main idea per slide; short phrases, not paragraphs.
- Large, readable font (at least 24 point for body text) and high contrast between text and background.
- Use relevant images, charts and diagrams; avoid heavy animation.
- Keep the design consistent: same fonts, colours and layout.
- Do not read the slides word for word; the slide supports you, you do not read from it.

- Start with a title slide, then an outline, content slides, a conclusion and a 'Thank you / Questions' slide.

UNIT V - LISTENING SKILLS AND NON-VERBAL COMMUNICATION

1. Importance of Listening

Listening is the most used communication skill. Good listening helps us understand instructions, learn, build relationships, avoid mistakes and respond properly. **Hearing** is a physical ability; **listening** is the active effort to understand meaning.

2. Basics of Listening

- **Stages:** receiving - understanding - remembering - evaluating - responding.
- **Types:** appreciative (enjoying music or a story), informational (learning a lecture), critical (judging an argument), empathetic (understanding feelings).
- **Active listening:** look at the speaker, do not interrupt, nod or say 'I see', ask questions, and repeat key points in your own words.

3. Barriers to Listening

Type	Examples
Physical	Noise, poor sound quality, uncomfortable room
Psychological	Stress, anger, worry, prejudice, lack of interest
Language	Unfamiliar words, heavy accent, fast speech
Attention	Daydreaming, thinking of a reply, using a phone
Information overload	Too much information at once

4. Listening for Gist, Style and Tone

- **Gist:** the main idea or general meaning. Ask: What is this mainly about?
- **Style:** how the message is expressed, formal or informal, simple or technical, friendly or serious.
- **Tone:** the speaker's attitude or feeling, such as angry, sad, sarcastic, cheerful or neutral. Tone is shown through pitch, pace and volume.

5. Voice Recording Exercises

- Record yourself reading a passage or speaking on a topic for one to two minutes.
- Play it back and note pronunciation, pace, pauses, clarity, volume and fillers.
- Re-record after practice and compare. Also record a short talk and write down its gist as a listening task.

6. Body Language

Non-verbal communication is communication without words. Experts commonly say that a large part of the impact of a message comes from tone and body language, so words and body language must match.

7. Importance of Body Language in Communication

- It reinforces, replaces or contradicts spoken words.
- It shows confidence, honesty, interest or nervousness.
- It helps in interviews, presentations, discussions and daily conversation.

8. Gestures, Posture, Eye Contact and Facial Expressions

Element	Meaning and good practice
Gestures	Hand and arm movements to emphasise points. Keep them natural and not distracting; avoid pointing a finger.
Posture	Stand or sit straight with shoulders relaxed to show confidence and respect. Avoid slouching or crossed arms, which can look closed or bored.
Eye contact	Look at the listener to show honesty and attention. Do not stare; in a group move your eyes across the audience.
Facial expressions	A genuine smile creates warmth. Expression should match the message (serious for serious news).
Proxemics	Use of space and distance. Keep a comfortable distance in conversation.
Paralanguage	Voice qualities such as pitch, pace, volume and pauses.
Haptics	Touch, for example a handshake; a firm, brief handshake is the norm in formal settings.

9. Etiquette

- Be punctual and dress suitably for the occasion.
- Greet politely, use 'please', 'thank you' and 'sorry'.
- Do not interrupt; wait for your turn to speak.
- Keep mobile phones silent and away during meetings and conversations.
- Show respect to all, irrespective of age or position, and be mindful of cultural differences.
- Telephone etiquette: identify yourself, speak clearly, be brief and polite, and thank the caller.

Recommended Reading

- Balan, K.R. and Rayudu, C.S. *Effective Communication*. Beacon, 1996.
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- Lewis, Norman. *Word Power Made Easy*. Penguin Publishers, 2015.
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- Wren, P.C. and Martin, H. *High School English Grammar and Composition*. Blackie Books, 2011.